sealed lid, all served with naan-like large breads, yoghurt, lime, and up to thirty kinds of pickles, which could include pickled quinces, bamboo, ginger, brinjal, sour lime, and mustard. There may have been dishes like murg zamindoz, popular at this time, which showed the fusing of Mughal and Rajput cooking traditions. The chicken, a quintessential Mughal ingredient, was well spiced and wrapped in dough, and then cooked under the earth using charcoal, a traditional Rajasthani technique for cooking vegetables. The food was flavoured with spices such as ginger, cinnamon, black pepper, cumin, cardamom, cloves, saffron, and coriander but would not have contained red chillies, potatoes, or tomatoes, which had not yet reached north India from the New World. Nor did the food contain kalonji, mustard seeds, sesame seeds or curry leaves, found in local market places but not incorporated into the Mughal kitchens, these indigenous spices probably still foreign to Central Asian and Persian palates.

There were fruits, however, for as Abu'l Fazl noted the Padshah 'looks upon fruits as one of the greatest gifts of the Creator, and pays much attention to them'. He brought the best horticulturists from Central Asia and Iran to supervise his orchards, which were watered with rose water to improve the flavour of the produce. To enhance the taste of the much-appreciated mangoes, milk and treacle were poured around the base of the trees. Akbar encouraged the cultivation of melons, peaches, apricots, walnuts, apples, pears, cherries, and pineapples, which were especially expensive, and sold in Delhi's market for the price of ten mangoes. With the passing decades, Akbar became more frugal in his eating habits restricting himself to just one meal a day, at no fixed time. This was not the case with the women in the harem and their complicated fasts, their many visitors, their varied cuisines. 'The food allowed to the women of the seraglio,' clarified Abu'l Fazl, 'commences to be taken from the kitchen in the morning and goes on till night.'

If the Padshah became more austere in his eating habits over the years, then the care and attention that went into the royal cuisine became ever more rigorous, as the fear of poison settled like a noxious stain in the fabric of Mughal life. Ever since the mother of the slain Ibrahim Lodi had tried to poison Babur after the Battle of Panipat, the fear of death by poisoning became an obsession that required constant vigilance. After the meals were prepared in the kitchens at Fatehpur Sikri, the cooks covered their mouths and noses with their hands as the food was taken out. The food was then